

Rider's Magic Mark Curriculum Companion



Pre-K–Grade 3 | Social-Emotional Learning | Teacher & Student Activities

© 2026 Tisha Shipley. All rights reserved.

Being Grateful for What Makes You Special: Caring Classroom Philosophy

Written and developed by Dr. Tisha Shipley

This curriculum and all accompanying materials are protected by copyright. No part of this publication may be reproduced, distributed, transmitted, stored, or shared in any form or by any means, electronic or mechanical, including photocopying, recording, scanning, or other methods, without prior written permission from the copyright holder, except for brief quotations used for educational or review purposes.

Educators who have legally purchased this curriculum may reproduce designated student activity pages for use with their own students. Reproduction for resale, redistribution, publication, or commercial use is prohibited without written permission from the author.

This curriculum is intended for educational purposes and is designed to support social-emotional learning, classroom community, and developmentally appropriate practices. It is not intended to replace professional judgment or individualized educational guidance.

All rights reserved.

First Edition, 2026

Published independently by Tisha Shipley

For permissions, educational partnerships, or other inquiries:

Tisha Shipley

www.ridersmagicmark.com

Rider's Magic Mark



SCAN ME!

Rider's Magic Mark™ and associated characters and creative elements are the property of Tisha Shipley. All rights reserved.

*****This curriculum includes alignment to the National Association for the Education of Young Children (NAEYC) and the Collaborative for Academic, Social, and Emotional Learning (CASEL). Because professional standards and frameworks may be revised over time, educators are encouraged to review the most current versions of these frameworks to ensure continued alignment with current guidance.

*******Welcome to the Rider's Magic Mark Companion! *******

This companion is designed to help children look a little closer, think a little deeper, and discover what makes each person special.

We recommend reading Rider's Magic Mark **two times**.

The first time, simply enjoy the story. Let children listen, look at the pictures, and experience Rider's adventure.

The second time, become a story detective! Take your time exploring the illustrations, discovering special vocabulary, noticing how the characters are alike and different, searching for hidden words, and talking about the story.

There are no “right” answers to many of the questions. The goal is to encourage children to notice, wonder, talk, and make connections to their own lives. And become aware that what makes them different is also what makes them unique and special.

Read #1: Read for FUN!

Enjoy the story from beginning to end.

Let children listen, look at the illustrations, and experience Rider’s adventure without stopping to complete activities or answer questions.

Read #2: Explore & DISCOVER! (this can even be on a different day)

Now it's time to look a little closer!

Read the story together again and encourage children to notice details they may have missed the first time.

Take your time. Look closely. Ask questions. Find clues. Talk about what you notice.

Lets get started!

Ways to Explore the Story

Picture Walk

Look closely at the illustrations. What do you notice? What do you wonder? What do you think is going to happen?

Vocabulary

Look for the special **BOLD** vocabulary words that appear throughout the story. These words are shown in bold so children can easily spot them.

Hidden Words

Search the illustrations for the hidden underlined words tucked throughout Rider's world. The hidden words are each characters Magic Mark.

Character Observations

Notice how the characters are alike and different. What makes each character special?

Questions

Ask questions that encourage children to think, wonder, explain, and make connections.

SEL Connections

Talk about feelings, strengths, courage, friendship, confidence, kindness, and what makes each person unique.

Visit Rider's Magic Mark website for journals, the Gratitude Curriculum, worksheets, hands-on activities, coloring sheets and ideas that extend the book.

Rider's Magic Mark



SCAN ME!

2nd time reading:

*****The words **ZAP** and **Magic Mark** are bold throughout the story—as they are important and make the story more magical!

Encourage children to watch for these words as they read. They become special words for Rider's story—and part of the fun of reading!

Listen for the Magic!

One special phrase appears throughout Rider's adventure:

“Everyone knew Magic was near.”

When this phrase appears, invite children to say it with you!

You can even create a special voice, action, or signal for the phrase.

This repeated phrase builds anticipation and gives children something familiar to listen for as the story unfolds.

Teacher/Family Tip:

The goal isn't simply to have children recognize the phrase. Encourage them to anticipate it, join in, and become part of the storytelling experience.

Vocabulary Words in the book:

Look Closely at the Words!

Special vocabulary words are shown in bold throughout the story. They are in bold letters.

As you read, pause when you come across a bold word. Talk about what the word means and how it connects to the story. Ask the child what it means to them.

Become a story detective!

Take your time exploring the illustrations, discovering special vocabulary, noticing how the characters are alike and different, searching for hidden underlined words, and talking about the story. These are found hidden in the illustrations.

Words to Know — Child-Friendly Definitions

Word	Page	Child-Friendly Definition
Magic Mark	3	A special mark that shows the amazing strengths inside a person.
Ordinary	6	Something that is usual or not different from what we normally see.
Unique	7	One-of-a-kind. There is nobody exactly like you!
Special	7	Important and wonderful in your own way.
Kindness	8	Being friendly, helpful, and caring toward others.
Strength	8	Something you are good at or something that helps you keep going.
Courage	8	Doing something even when you feel a little afraid.
Curious	9	Wanting to learn, discover, or know more about something.
Brave	9	Being willing to try or do something even when it feels scary.
Strong	9	Having the power to keep going, try your best, or handle something difficult.
Twinge	12	A quick little feeling, such as a tiny pinch or sudden feeling inside.
Zap	13	A quick burst of energy or light.
Courageous	21	Being brave when something is difficult, new, or scary.
Bravery	23	Being brave and facing something that may feel scary or difficult.
Adventure	26	An exciting experience where you explore, discover, or try something new.
Listening	27	Paying attention to what someone is saying.
Caring	27	Showing someone that you notice, love, and care about them.
Struggling	29	Having a hard time with something and needing help, practice, or encouragement.

Word	Page	Child-Friendly Definition
Strengths	30	The special things you are good at or ways you can help yourself and others.
Imagination	31	The ability to create pictures, ideas, and stories in your mind.
Create	31	To make or bring something new to life.
Witty	34	Being clever and funny with your words or ideas.
Funny	34	Something that makes people laugh or smile.
Humor	34	The ability to notice or create things that make people laugh or smile.
Joy	34	A happy feeling that makes you want to smile, laugh, or celebrate.
Pride	36	A happy feeling you have when you feel good about yourself or something you have done.

Page “Look Closely!” — What Children Can Find

8 What differences do you notice in the pictures around the room? Look for a wheelchair, hearing aids, walker, glasses, different hair colors, different skin colors, and prosthetics. A prosthetic is a special device that can replace a body part, such as an arm or leg, or help a person use their body.

9 What differences do you see? Look for hearing aids, different skin colors, different hair, and glasses. Talk about how everyone can look different and still have wonderful strengths.

17 Look closely! Rider's arm is glowing green. What do you think the green glow might mean?

19 Look at the map. Can you find the tree? Look closely at Jensen's wrist. What do you notice? Her wrist is glowing green!

22 Can you find the hidden word “Bravery” in the illustrations?

23 Jensen is being brave! Look closely. Both wrists are lit up. What else do you notice?

24 Look at the map. Can you find the pond? The map is lighting up!

25 Rider's arm zaps blue! What do you think the blue color might mean?

26 Look closely at Kash's ear. It is glowing blue! What might this tell us about Kash?

26–27 Can you find the hidden words: “listening,” and “caring”?

28 Look at the map. What place is lighting up? It is the playground.

29 Rider's arm zaps golden! What do you think that means? They are glowing golden too!

30 Can you find the hidden words “seeing the best in people”? Look closely at Cooper's glasses. What do you notice? They are glowing golden!

31 Rider's arm is glowing purple. Look at Cameron's sketchbook. It is glowing purple too!

Page “Look Closely!” — What Children Can Find

- 31** Can you find the hidden words “create” and “imagination”?
- 33** Rider's arm zaps red! What do you think the red color might mean?
- 34** Look at Tripp's legs. They are glowing red! Can you find the hidden word “humor”?
- 35** Look closely! All of the characters' Magic Marks and colors are glowing. What do you notice about all of their different colors?
- 37** Look at Rider's arm. It is glowing with all of his friends' colors! What do you think this tells us about Rider and his friends?

38–39

Diversity Celebration! Look closely at all the people in the pictures. What differences do you notice? Can you find different skin tones, hair colors and textures, glasses, hearing aids, a wheelchair, a prosthetic leg, service dog, a child with Down syndrome, a blind child, alopecia, and a Dexcom? Can you find Rider's birthmark? Talk about how people may look, move, communicate, and experience the world in different ways. Every person is unique and special! You can explain to the children what each one of these do, and what they are finding are marks that are on the outside.

Next, talk about the special “marks” we carry on the inside. Just like Kash’s mark shows empathy, listening, and caring, Jensen’s mark shows bravery, and Tripp’s mark shows humor, each person has special strengths that make them who they are.

Page 41: Author

The author is the person who writes the words and creates the story. The author decides what happens in the story, who the characters are, and what message the story shares.

Illustrator

The illustrator is the person who creates the pictures that bring the story to life. The illustrator uses art, colors, expressions, and details to help readers see the characters, places, and ideas in the story.

Page 42 and 43

Together, the author and illustrator help create the whole story! The author uses words, and the illustrator uses pictures to help readers imagine, understand, and enjoy the book.

The characters in *Rider's Magic Mark* are inspired by real people! On these pages, you can see each person in real life alongside their illustrated character from the book.

Each person has also shared their real-life signature and a special quote that expresses their own Magic Mark, or the unique strength that makes them who they are.

As you look at these pages, invite children to think about:

- What makes each person unique?
- What strength or quality do you notice?
- How does their quote describe their Magic Mark?
- What might your own Magic Mark be?

Every person has something special to share with the world. Our differences, strengths, and unique qualities are part of what makes us shine!

Helpful questions you can ask throughout the book.

Before Reading — Get Ready to Explore

- **What do you notice about the cover?**
- **What do you think a “Magic Mark” might be?**
- **What do you think this story might be about?**
- **What do you notice about Rider?**
- **What are you wondering about?**
- **Have you ever had something about you that made you feel special?**
- **What do you think makes someone special?**

While Reading — Look, Think & Wonder

- **What do you notice in this picture?**
- **What do you think Rider is feeling? What makes you think that?**
- **What do you think might happen next?**
- **What clues do you see in the picture?**
- **Why do you think Rider's Magic Mark changed color?**
- **What do you think this color might mean?**
- **What is Rider discovering about himself?**
- **What do you notice about the other characters?**
- **How are the characters alike? How are they different?**
- **Why do you think everyone's mark is different?**
- **What strength do you think this character has?**
- **What makes you think that?**
- **How is the character showing courage?**
- **Where do you see kindness in the story?**
- **How is someone being a good friend?**
- **What could the character do if they are struggling?**

- Who is listening? How can you tell?
- Who is showing empathy? What did they do?
- What do you think the character is feeling inside?
- Can you find a hidden word?
- Can you find something in the picture that you didn't notice before?
- What does the map tell us?
- Why do you think the map is lighting up?
- What do you think the glowing colors mean?

When the Characters Discover Their Strengths SEL Focus:

- What is Jensen's strength?
- How does Jensen show bravery?
- What is Kash good at?
- How does Kash show empathy?
- How does Kash show that he is listening?
- What does it mean to care about someone?
- What is Cameron's strength?
- How does Cameron use her imagination?
- What does it mean to be creative?
- What makes Tripp funny?
- How can humor help people?
- What is Cooper helping the children discover?
- What do you think Rider is learning from his friends?

Questions About Differences & Inclusion

- What differences do you notice among the characters?
- What makes each character unique?
- Can two people look different and still have something in common?

- Why is it important to notice people's strengths instead of only noticing their differences?
- How can we make sure everyone feels included?
- What can we learn from someone who is different from us?
- What makes you unique?
- What is a strength you have that other people might not have?
- How can our differences make a group stronger?

Connect It to the Child

- What is something you are really good at?
- What is a strength you have?
- When have you been brave?
- When have you shown kindness?
- When have you helped a friend?
- When have you listened carefully to someone?
- When have you used your imagination?
- What makes you unique?
- What is something special about you?
- If you had a Magic Mark, what color would it be?
- What would your Magic Mark show about you?
- What would your friends say is one of your strengths?

There may not be one “right” answer. The goal is to encourage children to observe, think, communicate, and make connections.

Connect the Story to YOU

Rider’s story gives children opportunities to think about their own lives.

Through conversation and activities, children will:

- identify and discuss character strengths
 - make connections between the story and their own experiences
 - recognize similarities and differences among people
 - explore feelings and emotions
 - develop confidence and self-awareness
 - appreciate the strengths and uniqueness of others
 - practice expressing their ideas and perspectives
-

Take the Story Home

Families continue to have conversations

Ask three people in your family:

“What is something that makes you special?”

Then invite the child to:

Draw what they discovered.

or

Write what they discovered.

or

Share what they learned with the group.

Encourage children to notice that every person may have different strengths, interests, experiences, and qualities—and that those differences are something to appreciate.

Keep Exploring!

The learning doesn't have to end when the story ends!

Visit Rider’s Magic Mark for all extension and printable ideas.

 **Coloring pages**

 **Printable journals**

-  Discussion guides
 -  Writing and reflection activities
 -  Hands-on activities
 -  Family activities
 -  Classroom activities
 - Printable certificates
-

Want to Go Deeper?

If you are looking for a more in-depth curriculum to use alongside *Rider's Magic Mark*, explore the Growing Gratitude & Confidence Curriculum.

It extends the themes of Rider's story through additional classroom, family, SEL, and confidence-building experiences.

Scan the QR code or visit RidersMagicMark.com to explore all of the FREE Rider's Magic Mark resources.

Rider's Magic Mark



SCAN ME!